A Simheuristic for the Team Orienteering Problem with Stochastic Travel Times on the Small Chao Instances

Heuristic Algorithms in Transport and Finance — Master's course assignment

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Abstract

In the Team Orienteering Problem (TOP) with stochastic travel times, m vehicles collect optional rewards within a time limit per route, and a route that arrives late loses its reward. We implement in Python the simheuristic of Juan et al. (2019): savings-based candidates with biased randomisation and local search, then a fast and an intensive Monte Carlo simulation. Over the 141 feasible instances of Chao's sets p1–p3 and three variance levels, the mean gap to the deterministic best-known solutions is 14.65, 25.02 and 30.51 %, with medians 7–9 points above those read from the paper's figure; a run takes 0.05–0.23 s. About 80–90 % of the gap is lost in the simulation: candidates built with expected times fill the time limit, and on average 13–29 % of winning routes arrive late on a simulated day.

1 Introduction

A fleet of m drones leaves a depot to visit customers that each pay a reward, and every drone must reach a final depot within its battery time $t_{\max}$. Not every customer can be visited: one decides which customers each vehicle serves and in which order, maximising the total reward. This is the Team Orienteering Problem (TOP) of Chao et al. [2], which is NP-hard. In the *stochastic* variant of Juan et al. [1] travel times are random and a vehicle that arrives after $t_{\max}$ loses the whole reward of its route, so the goal is the *expected* reward, which has to be estimated by simulation. Juan et al. compare the sample average approximation (SAA), solved with CPLEX, with a *simheuristic*: a heuristic whose candidates are evaluated by Monte Carlo simulation. We implement only the simheuristic, since the SAA needs a commercial solver.

The instances are those of Chao et al. [2], with random travel times as in [1]. An instance named `p1.2.a` belongs to set 1, has $m = 2$ vehicles and the smallest $t_{\max}$ of the set-1 instances with two vehicles. We use sets p1, p2 and p3 (32, 21 and 33 nodes), the only ones below 35 nodes, on which Juan et al. could also run the SAA. Each file gives m, $t_{\max}$ and the coordinates and reward of every node. Six p1 instances have no reachable customer, which leaves 141 (48, 33 and 60 per set), with $t_{\max}$ from 3.8 to 55; the references are the deterministic best-known solutions (BKS) of [5]. Below we state the model, describe the simheuristic and our implementation, and compare with Figure 3 of [1].

2 The stochastic model

Node 0 is the origin depot, $1,\dots,n$ the customers and $n+1$ the destination depot. Customer i pays $u_i \geq 0$ the first time it is visited, and $t_{ij} = t_{ji}$, the unrounded Euclidean distance, is the expected travel time. As in [1], the actual time is $T_{ij} \sim \text{LogNormal}(\mu_{ij}, \sigma_{ij})$ with $E[T_{ij}] = t_{ij}$ and $\text{Var}[T_{ij}] = c\,t_{ij}$, i.e. $\sigma_{ij}^2 = \ln(1 + c/t_{ij})$ and $\mu_{ij} = \ln t_{ij} - \sigma_{ij}^2/2$, with three levels: low (L, $c = 0.05$), medium (M, 0.25) and high (H, 0.75). For $t_{ij} = 10$ the coefficient of variation is 7.1, 15.8 and 27.4 %. We assume independent arcs, which the paper does not state. A solution is a set of at most m routes $r_d = (i_1,\dots,i_k)$, travelled as $0 \to r_d \to n+1$, with expected time $E_d = t_{0i_1} + \cdots + t_{i_k,n+1}$, random time T_d and reward $U(r_d) = \sum_{i \in r_d} u_i$:

$$\max\ E\Big[\sum_{d=1}^{m} \mathbf{1}\{T_d \leq t_{\max}\}\,U(r_d)\Big] \qquad \text{s.t.} \qquad r_d \cap r_e = \emptyset\ (d \neq e), \qquad E_d \leq t_{\max} \quad (d = 1,\dots,m). \tag{1}$$

Read literally: the objective is the expected reward of the routes that arrive in time; the first constraint pays every customer at most once; the second is the design constraint of [1] (their Eq. 3): routes are planned with expected times, and the real time may exceed $t_{\max}$ at the cost of the route's reward. With $c \to 0$ the model is the deterministic TOP.

Two properties drive the results. First, with independent arcs the variances add up, so $\text{Var}[T_d] = c\,E_d$ and the relative standard deviation is $\sqrt{c/E_d}$: the same c weighs more on short routes. For a route that fills $t_{\max}$ with $c = 0.25$ it is 25.6 % if $t_{\max} = 3.8$ and 6.7 % if $t_{\max} = 55$. Second, a route whose expected time equals $t_{\max}$ fails almost half of the time: a test route of four arcs of length 2.5, $t_{\max} = 10$ and $c = 0.25$ arrived late in 47.18 % of 20 000 replicas, slightly below one half because the lognormal is skewed to the right and its median lies below its mean. Slack is worth reward.

3 The simheuristic

The method separates building solutions quickly with expected times from judging them by simulation [1]. One run for an instance, a level c and a weight α has six steps:

1. **Candidates.** The savings heuristic of Panadero et al. [3] (PJS) starts with a route $0 \to i \to n+1$ per reachable customer. For every ordered pair it computes the time saved by joining the route that ends at i with the one that starts at j, $s_{ij} = t_{i,n+1} + t_{0j} - t_{ij}$ (both directions, since the depots differ), and the *preference* $s'_{ij} = \alpha\, s_{ij} + (1-\alpha)(u_i + u_j)$. Walking the list in decreasing s'_{ij}, it merges two different routes whenever the merged expected time fits in $t_{\max}$, and keeps the m routes of largest reward. We run it greedily once and 50 times with *biased randomisation* [4]: the next arc

Table 1: Gap to the deterministic BKS (%), best α per (instance, c), 141 instances per level. *Paper*: SimHeu-L/M/H of Figure 3 of [1], read by eye ($\pm$1–2 points). *Det. gap* and *Loss*: deterministic gap and loss due to uncertainty, both relative to the BKS (means; they add up to the mean gap); *Failed*: share of routes late on a day of the intensive simulation (mean); *BKS det.*: winners whose deterministic reward equals the BKS. Each level is a different problem, so no overall mean is given.

Level	c	Ours: median (Q1–Q3)	Ours mean	Paper: median (Q1–Q3)	p1 mean	p2 mean	p3 mean	Det. gap	Loss	Failed routes	BKS det.
L	0.05	15.69 (9.90–20.23)	14.65	≈7 (5–10)	18.38	10.36	14.02	3.15	11.50	12.73	72
M	0.25	26.02 (20.04–31.97)	25.02	≈17 (9–20)	29.37	19.33	24.68	2.96	22.06	23.57	72
H	0.75	31.56 (26.35–36.44)	30.51	≈24 (19–28)	33.87	25.19	30.75	2.41	28.10	29.45	82

is the one in position $\lfloor \ln U / \ln(1-\beta) \rfloor \bmod L$ of the L arcs left, $U \sim \mathrm{Unif}(0,1]$, so with $\beta = 0.3$ the first arc is taken 30 % of the time. Every candidate then goes through a local search: 2-opt with first improvement on each route, then insertion of the unvisited customer of highest reward that fits, at its cheapest position, repeated until none fits.

2. **Deduplication.** Identical solutions (same routes in any order) are kept once.
3. **Deterministic filter.** The 7 distinct candidates of highest deterministic reward go on (all of them if there are fewer).
4. **Fast simulation.** The 7 are evaluated on the same 200 replicas (*days*) of all travel times; the 3 with the highest mean reward go on.
5. **Intensive simulation.** The 3 finalists are evaluated on 1000 *new* days, shared by the three.
6. **Winner.** The finalist with the highest intensive mean, which estimates its expected reward.

Common days to compare, new days to measure. The fast simulation has to *rank* 7 candidates with only 200 replicas. With *common random numbers* the difference between two candidates comes from their routes, not from luck in the draw: $\mathrm{Var}(\bar{R}_A - \bar{R}_B) = \mathrm{Var}(\bar{R}_A) + \mathrm{Var}(\bar{R}_B) - 2\,\mathrm{Cov}(\bar{R}_A, \bar{R}_B)$, and the covariance is positive on common days. The intensive simulation must instead *measure*. The finalists were chosen because they did well on the fast days; measured again on them, their means would inherit that luck (the *winner's curse*). The 1000 days are thus drawn with another generator and do not include the 200. Common is not the same as reused: candidates of the same phase share their days, but the days that selected a solution never measure it. A small bias remains, since the reported mean is the largest of three; with 1000 replicas and similar finalists it is negligible, and removing it would need a third simulation of the winner.

The greedy candidate guarantees that the best candidate in deterministic reward is no worse than PJS plus local search, but not that the final solution is: the winner is chosen by simulation, and the greedy one may not even pass the filter. The price of the design is that every step before the simulation uses expected times, so routes are filled up to $t_{\max}$ and the filter keeps the fullest. We keep this choice, faithful to the paper, and measure its effect in Section 5.

4 Implementation

The code is written in Python 3.14 with NumPy 2.5.4 and Numba 0.68.1. The module `simtop.py` holds the model and the simheuristic, `run_experiment.py` the experiment, `checks.py` 18 sanity checks and the notebook `analysis.ipynb` the tables and figures. The PJS merges, the local search and the loop over replicas are Numba kernels; random numbers are drawn with NumPy, and each day is an $N \times N$ matrix of symmetric times read by all the candidates of a phase.

Juan et al. describe their simheuristic in one paragraph without parameter values; only the levels of c and the 200 and 1000 replicas come from [1]. The rest is ours: $\alpha \in \{0.25, 0.5, 0.75\}$, all three run, because s_{ij} and $u_i + u_j$ have different scales; $\beta = 0.3$, as in our TOP assignment; 50 iterations instead of a time limit, for reproducibility; the filter $7 \to 3$, to keep a run within seconds; and the local search of our TOP assignment instead of their destruction–reconstruction plus 2-opt. As a check, the greedy PJS gives exactly the reward of that assignment for the three α on the 141 instances.

Each (instance, c, α) is run once, 1 269 runs, with seed `SeedSequence([2019, i, k, l])`, the indices of the instance (alphabetical order), of c and of α, split into three generators (biased randomisation, fast and intensive simulation). For each (instance, c) we keep the best α, 423 cases; levels are never mixed, since each c is a different problem. With $\bar{R}$ the intensive mean of the winner and *det* its deterministic reward, $\mathrm{gap} = 100\,(\mathrm{BKS} - \bar{R})/\mathrm{BKS}$. It is the sum of the *deterministic gap* $100\,(\mathrm{BKS} - \mathrm{det})/\mathrm{BKS}$, lost by the heuristic, and the *loss due to uncertainty* $100\,(\mathrm{det} - \bar{R})/\mathrm{BKS}$, lost by late routes, both measured against the BKS. Times cover one call to the simheuristic, once the Numba kernels are loaded; a process pool spreads the runs over 12 threads of a 6-core AMD Ryzen 5 5500U.

5 Computational results

Table 1 summarises, per level, the gap of the best α of each instance next to the simheuristic boxes of Figure 3 of [1], and Figure 1 draws both.

Comparison with the paper. The gap grows with the uncertainty, L < M < H, as in the paper, but our medians are 7–9 points higher (15.69, 26.02 and 31.56 % against about 7, 17 and 24 %), and at L and M our lower quartile is about their upper one. The comparison is approximate: the values are read by eye, and the paper says neither which instances enter each box (we assume p1–p3, the only sets solved by the SAA) nor how the gap is computed. Our deterministic gap is only 2.4–3.2 points, so the difference does not come mainly from the construction. A plausible cause is that Juan et al. simulate inside the search loop and stop by time (their Figure 4 shows runs of up to about 400 s), so simulation can steer the search towards routes with slack, whereas we simulate only 7 candidates chosen with expected times; we cannot check it without their code.

Most of the gap is lost to uncertainty. The median deterministic gap is zero at every level: in 72, 72 and 82 of the 141 cases the winner reaches the BKS in deterministic terms. The deterministic gap accounts for only 2.4–3.2 points and the loss due to uncertainty for 11.50, 22.06 and 28.10, about 80 % of the gap at L and 90 % at M and H. Measured on

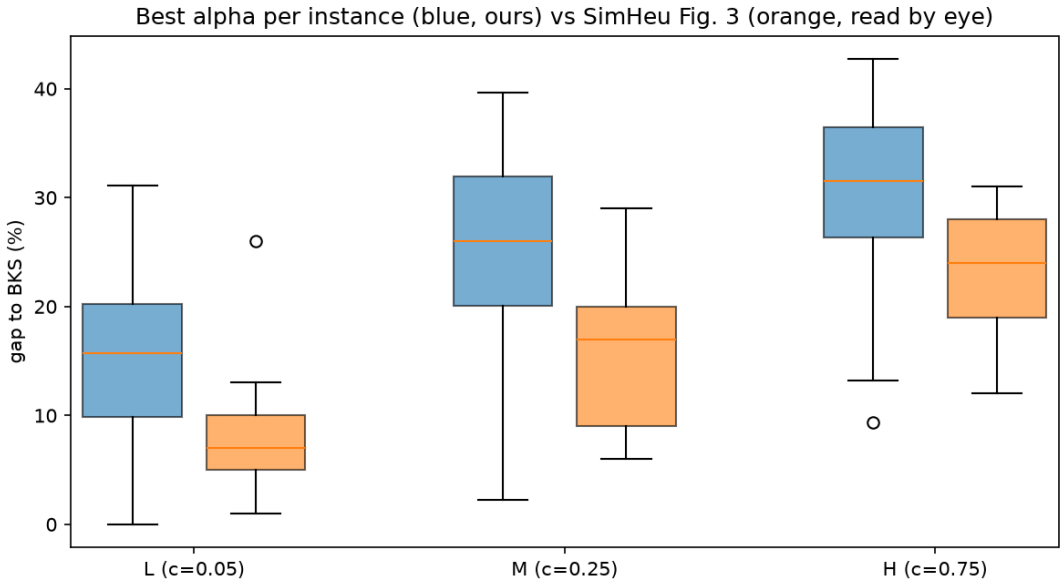


Figure 1: Gap to the deterministic BKS per level, best α per instance. Blue: our 141 instances (boxes Q1–Q3, line at the median, whiskers up to 1.5 IQR, circles beyond). Orange: SimHeu boxes of Figure 3 of [1], read by eye.

the winner's own reward, the loss is 11.86, 22.72 and 28.79 %, almost the share of routes that arrive late on a simulated day (12.73, 23.57 and 29.45 %), as expected when a late route loses everything. Part of it no solution can avoid. A likely reason for its size is the one announced in Section 3: the median expected time of the winners' routes is $0.93\,t_{\max}$ at every level, and 4, 6 and 8 % of them lie within 1 % of $t_{\max}$, where a route fails almost half of the time. The simulation also often has little to choose from: in 27.1 % of the 1 269 runs fewer than 7 distinct candidates survive, so the filter does not act, and in 9.0 % only one does.

The weight α hardly matters. Over the 1 269 runs the mean gap of each fixed α varies by less than 0.6 points within each level, and the best α is 0.25, 0.5 and 0.75 in 142, 138 and 143 cases. Yet keeping the best α per case lowers the mean gap by 1.3–2.2 points, partly through the selection bias of picking the best of three with the reported mean.

Set and $t_{\max}$. Since short routes are relatively more variable, one would expect larger gaps for small $t_{\max}$. The data show the opposite: the gap tends to grow with $t_{\max}$ (Spearman 0.49, 0.56 and 0.67 for L, M and H), and p2, with the smallest $t_{\max}$ (median 10.0 against 17.5 in p1 and 20.6 in p3), has the lowest gap. But the deterministic gap also grows with $t_{\max}$ (0.56, 0.54 and 0.59), more than the loss due to uncertainty (0.30, 0.39 and 0.44), and set and $t_{\max}$ are confounded, since p2 has only 21 nodes: we report the trend as an observation, not an explanation.

Time. A run takes 0.053–0.234 s (means 0.16–0.17 s in p1 and p3, 0.07 s in p2), and the 1 269 runs about 25 s on 12 threads. Figure 4 of [1] reports a few seconds to about 400 s in Java on a 3.7 GHz Xeon with a time limit, so only a qualitative comparison makes sense. Runs this cheap let us try every α at every level instead of tuning one.

6 Conclusions

The simheuristic builds candidates for a deterministic world and lets Monte Carlo simulation, on common days to rank and new days to measure, choose among them. On the 141 small Chao instances it gives the ordering L < M < H of Juan et al., with mean gaps of 14.65, 25.02 and 30.51 %, in a fraction of a second per run. The winners usually match the BKS in deterministic terms, but the median route fills $0.93\,t_{\max}$ and on average 13–29 % of the routes arrive late on a simulated day: simulation can only choose among routes built without slack. The next step is a safety margin: building with $t_{\max} - \delta$ while simulating with the true $t_{\max}$, with δ from a grid, from the route variance ($E_d + z\sqrt{c\,E_d} \le t_{\max}$) or adapted to the failure rate of the fast simulation.

References

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